

Create and Mount a Virtual Hard Drive

What if you could have a virtual hard drive all within a file on your real hard drive? Does this seem like something you would want to do?

It is now quite simple with Windows 8, you can create a virtual hard drive file, which when “attached” to the computer shows up just like an external hard drive would. Such a virtual hard drive can even have multiple partitions like a physical drive.

Windows has native support for the VHD virtual hard drive format and in Windows 8 added support for the VHDX format. Creating a drive in any one of these formats is simple:

- ▶ With the Windows start screen open type “diskmgmt.msc” and press enter to launch the Disk Management tool.
- ▶ Click on the Action menu and select Create VHD.
- ▶ You can now pick the format and type of the drive. If you’re still using older versions of Windows, or might need to use the virtual hard drive on other computers, choose VHD, otherwise choose VHDX.
- ▶ A fixed size disk gives better performance, but will take up space immediately. If you make a 10GB fixed size disk, it will need 10GB of space on your actual drive. On the other hand a dynamically expanding disk will initially take up only a few MB, but will expand as you store more data on it.
- ▶ Enter a size and choose a location for the virtual hard drive and click OK.
- ▶ Your drive will now be created, and should show up in the Disk Management tool.

You can now use the Disk Management tool to create partitions on this disk and format those partitions just like you would for a normal drive.

You will also notice that partitions from this drive will show up in Explorer and you can begin copying files like normal. Once you are done, you can right click on the all the partitions and select the eject option. Once all partitions are ejected, you can move the virtual hard drive file around wherever you want, even to another computer. Attaching it again to access it is as simple as double clicking the file.

If you want you can password protect these drives. For this you can use the inbuilt BitLocker feature of Windows, which allows you to encrypt entire drives, whether portable, fixed or virtual. If you encrypt the drive, you will be prompted for a password when you attach the drive and try to open it.

Gestures in Windows 8

Being the touch centred operating system that it is, Windows 8 includes